

Research Paper

Artificial Intelligence in Turkish Educational Research Journals Publishing in English: Policies, Ethics, and Stakeholder Perspectives

Hüsem Korkmaz^{*a}^a(ORCID ID: 0000-0002-5759-7392), Manisa Celal Bayar University, School of Foreign Languages, Department of Foreign Languages, Manisa, Türkiye, husem.korkmaz@cbu.edu.tr^{*}Corresponding author

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ABSTRACT

This study is an attempt to gain insight into the adoption of generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) policies by Turkish educational research journals publishing manuscripts in English. With this aim, the educational research journals indexed in the Turkish national indexing database, TR Dizin, were chosen as the sample of the study. After implementing the exclusion criteria, such as having a predominantly non-educational scope or being under evaluation for the year 2025, a total of 107 journals comprised the sample. The journal contents were carefully examined to find out any AI use policy, and the contents of these policies were qualitatively analysed. In order to delve deeper into the phenomenon, semi-structured interviews were conducted with various stakeholders of scholarly publishing such as publishers, chief-editors, editors, and authors. The data collected were analysed using thematic analysis in order to identify relevant codes and themes. The findings indicated that the majority of Turkish educational research journals lack declared policies regarding the AI use. Those adopting AI policies commonly prohibited the use of AI in generating data and transferring the responsibility of authorship to AI while they cautiously permitted using AI as a proof-reader, a data analysis assistant, and a language correction tool. The interview findings pointed to the need to adopt and declare clear AI use policies and highlighted the inevitability of utilizing AI tools in scholarly publishing while also drawing attention to the ethical considerations and risks resulting from the current capabilities of AI.



INTRODUCTION

Scholarly writing is a complex, challenging, and distinctive style of writing in general with its unique features, organisation, priorities, and lexical coverage (Pereira et al., 2024; Rahimi & Zhang, 2018). In order to successfully get accepted, scholars and researchers need to meet a series of criteria depending on the journal or the citation index they intend to publish in. The rapid development of artificial intelligence (AI) has tremendously impacted numerous sectors, including academic publishing all around the world. In the same way, the use of generative AI tools in scholarly writing has increasingly been a common issue of debate in the last several years. A recent study by Van Noorden & Perkel (2023) reported that one-fourth of researchers make use of AI tools while preparing their manuscripts. Considering the time passed, the percentage is even higher now. AI tools and applications are utilized by researchers especially while reviewing the literature, translating from other languages, summarising other scholarly publications, analysing and reporting data, and generating catchy but comprehensive titles for papers (Glickman & Zhang, 2024; Hutson, 2022). In this regard, AI technologies have the potential to transform how scientific research is carried out, disseminated, and reviewed. Although many of these reported capabilities of AI tools are likely to enhance the quality of the publications, they also give rise to ethical concerns regarding authorship, transparency, human-judgement, information bias, fairness, and accountability (Barros et al., 2023).

As scientific productivity is determined by the quality and quantity of scholarly publications, researchers and academics strive hard to publish quality papers in internationally renowned journals, which is a process directly affected by the language factor (Lillis & Curry, 2010). Similarly, in Turkish academic context, researchers struggle to publish high quality manuscripts in English, which is the *Lingua Franca* of the academic world, in order to gain international recognition, be placed in academic positions, get promotion, and receive more citations from international prestigious journals and researchers. Besides, universities in Türkiye have consistently been increasing their publication demands from academics to be appointed to academic positions or for contract renewals. In such an atmosphere of “publish or perish”, AI might seem to be a good companion to assist researchers in their endeavours to prepare “publishable” pieces of scientific work. Although AI presents an opportunity to address many of the challenges of preparing scientific manuscripts, it also comes up with serious concerns regarding the responsible use of this potentially “false” friend (Altmäe et al., 2023; Borenstein & Howard, 2021). It is also evident that the adoption of AI technologies in Turkish academic publishing has been uneven, and many journals have yet to establish clear policies regarding the ethical and responsible use of AI tools in publishing processes. Indeed, the potential of AI to radically alter the nature of conventional publishing practices and to make way for a number of unethical actions has prompted the development of AI policies in scholarly journals. While there is research on the AI policies of the major publishers, indexing services, and academic journals in the world, there is limited knowledge regarding the evolving

norms surrounding AI utilisation in manuscript preparation and the potential enforcement of these rules by the publishers or journals (Chemaya & Martin, 2024). Moreover, although there is a scarcity of research on the use of AI for editing purposes in academic writing (e.g. Dönbak, 2024), there have been no attempts to uncover the existing AI use policies in Turkish educational journals publishing in English, particularly in terms of understanding the views of key stakeholders, such as publishers, editors, authors, and reviewers. This study seeks to fill this gap by exploring the current state of AI use policies in Turkish educational research journals and investigating the perspectives of key stakeholders on the role of generative AI in the publishing process. By analysing the adoption of AI technologies in these journals and the ethical concerns raised by stakeholders, this research will contribute to a better understanding of how AI is reshaping scholarly publishing in Türkiye and provide insights for the development of comprehensive AI use policies. Hence, this study examines (1) the prevalence and nature of AI policies in Turkish educational journals and (2) stakeholders' perceptions of AI's ethical and practical roles in scholarly publishing by answering the following research questions:

1. To what extent and in what ways do the Turkish educational research journals adopt explicit policies regarding the use of generative AI?
2. How do the stakeholders involved in scholarly publishing perceive the potential benefits, challenges, and ethical implications of integrating AI into scholarly publishing?
3. How is generative AI expected to influence scholarly publishing processes in Türkiye in the future?

Theoretical Background

The scope of the present study is driven by two distinct theoretical foundations. Being the first one, the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM) introduced by Davis (1989) provides a comprehensive framework to explore the adoption of current AI technologies by the academic publishing stakeholders. In this regard, TAM has been utilized as a critical lens to explore the perceptions of stakeholders in terms of the perceived usefulness and ease of use of the AI technologies in manuscript preparation, evaluation, and publication processes. Besides, extended versions of TAM such as TAM2 (Venkatesh & Davis, 2000) also help researchers understand the behavioural intentions and subjective norms towards accepting and using contemporary technologies in scholarly publishing, and why certain journals have adopted more progressive AI policies.

As another underlying theory, Information Ethics Theory (Floridi, 2007; 2013) comprises an essential framework for delving into the moral dimensions of AI policy integration in scholarly publishing, particularly for Turkish educational journals publishing in English language and navigating complex international publishing world. By extending beyond the traditional human-centred approaches to consider the moral worth of information, the Information Ethics Theory offers critical insights into how journals are establishing normative boundaries for AI use (Floridi, 2013).

Use of AI in scholarly publications and ethical considerations

Artificial intelligence, in its latest generative form, is capable of fulfilling countless tasks in many fields of daily, professional, and academic life. Especially with the advent of large language models (LLMs) such as ChatGPT, Gemini, AI has become even more popular among researchers who aim to carry out research on it or who want to make use of it while doing scientific research (Wu et al., 2025). LLMs have proven to be efficient tools to generate research ideas, recommend research designs, plan and implement research steps, collect and analyse data, review and revise manuscripts, and proofread articles to eliminate ethical concerns such as plagiarism and data fabrication. Besides, generative AI technology is even considered as guarantor of equity between native and non-native English speakers in disseminating scientific knowledge by helping them overcome the language barrier in the global publishing sphere (Barros et al., 2023). Nevertheless, as Altmäe et al. (2023) assert, there have been concerns regarding the efficiency of AI in assisting researchers such as the dissemination of false or made-up information (hallucinations), intellectual property rights violations, biased information, authorship issues, and transparency (Borenstein & Howard, 2021).

Academic integrity within the scope of scholarly publishing encompasses the devotion to universal professional and ethical best practices with utmost honesty, accountability, and transparency (Kretser et al., 2019). There have been several precautions and commonly accepted norms to draw the boundaries of ethical and unethical behaviours in academic publishing such as plagiarism and its detection, or copyright issues. However, the advancements in science, the evolution of scholarly publishing, and the emergency of cutting edge technologies have made it an obligation to revise the existing norms, principles, and practices regarding the academic publishing ethics (Bhavsar et al., 2025; Larivière et al., 2015). In order to cope with the academic integrity concerns regarding the aforementioned ethical issues, there have been several attempts to, at least, identify unethical use of AI in scholarly publications. With this purpose in mind, some leading technology companies and scholarly publishing authorities have been involved in the development of so called "AI detectors", which have soon been demonstrated inaccuracies in detecting or quantifying the presence of AI traces in a given text (Hu, 2024; Wiggers, 2023). Even the online plagiarism detection tool Turnitin, which claimed to come up with ignorable percentages (<1 %) of false-positive rates (Turnitin, 2023), still warns its users regarding the probability of inaccurate AI detection in the documents scanned.

Addressing the ethical concerns regarding the use of AI in scientific writing remains to be a remarkably challenging and controversial issue. That is why there has been no single and commonly accepted publication policy framework introduced by the mainstream publishers or journals yet. Although there have been several recommended tenets introduced by global publishers, they are still far from preventing unethical actions. For example, Nature (2023) clearly declared that no AI tool or application can be

credited as an author and that researchers who employ any AI technology in manuscript preparation need to declare their use in their manuscripts. However, many AI policy attempts, like the one introduced by Nature, seem to ignore the fact that AI-generated documents are not easily identifiable since they are trained by human language input (García-Peñalvo, 2023), and there are no fully reliable means to enforce such policies. Therefore, in the absence of such tools, well-intentioned initiatives are likely to stay merely theoretical (Hu, 2024). Besides, the publishers and editors rely heavily on the authors regarding their potential use of generative AI technologies while preparing their manuscripts (Hosseini et al., 2023).

Policies and Perspectives on the Use of AI in Scholarly Publishing

However hard it is to ensure the avoidance or ethical use of AI (Hu, 2024), the scholarly publishers and individual journals cannot remain indifferent to the issue of AI use in scholarly writing process. In the academic publishing sphere, it can be observed that leading publishers have already alternated and declared their updated ethical policies on the use of AI and LLMs. According to a recent global study with a large scale sampling of publishers, it was found that 82.1 % of the mainstream academic publishers involved in the study necessitate the authors to declare any use of AI or LLMs with only 34.6 % having a publicly available AI use policy, 91.1 % reject the authorship of AI in the manuscripts, and 7.1 % strictly prohibit the use of AI in any phase of the manuscript preparation (Bhavsar et al., 2025). It was also discovered that AI use could be allowed by the publisher for purposes of image generation, proofreading, determining the research methods, and writing the non-methodological parts of the manuscript. In an earlier study on 300 journals, Lund and Naheem (2024) stated that almost 60 % of top journals had AI policies available to the scholarly readers and the public. However, they also noted that the contents of these policies were mainly guided by the publishers rather than the individual journals (Lund & Naheem, 2024).

Despite a number of common policies such as authorship, transparency, and linguistic proofreading, the existing AI policies still lack consensus on the use of AI tools and applications in data collection, data analysis, and non-methodological sections and reviewing tasks (Bhavsar et al., 2025; Ebadi et al., 2025; Lund & Naheem, 2024). Furthermore, it is crucial for the stakeholders of scholarly publishing to identify and eliminate the risks caused by AI, and to decide where to place this contemporary technology (Teel et al., 2023).

In the Turkish context, it is important to note that national institutions play a significant role in shaping the scholarly publishing landscape and influencing policy development. The Council of Higher Education (2024) establishes the broader framework for academic standards and AI use in academic writing through its recently released ethics guide, which draws on possible ethical violations caused by the use of AI in scientific research and publication processes, and serves as a foundational reference for journal policies across Turkish academia. The Scientific and Technological Research Council of Türkiye (TÜBİTAK), through its TR Dizin indexing system, also sets quality standards and ethical guidelines that indexed journals must adhere to, with journals periodically re-evaluated and potentially removed if they fail to meet established criteria (TÜBİTAK ULAKBİM, n.d.). However, despite these institutional structures, there remains limited evidence of coordinated national-level initiatives specifically addressing AI governance in scholarly publishing, leaving individual journals to carry out AI policy development largely independently or in response to international publisher requirements.

METHOD

This study employs a mixed-methods approach to thoroughly examine the AI use policies of Turkish educational journals indexed in the national TR Dizin database. By combining content analysis with semi-structured interviews, the research aims to explore the current state of AI integration in scholarly publishing, ethical considerations, and the future impact of AI on academic journals in Türkiye.

Research Design

The research follows a descriptive, exploratory design, utilizing both quantitative and qualitative methods. The first phase involves content analysis of the AI policies of Turkish educational journals, while the second phase focuses on qualitative interviews with key stakeholders in academic publishing to gain a deeper understanding of their views and experiences regarding AI policies.

Sample

Turkish educational research journals publishing in English

The initial sample for the content analysis consisted of 142 Turkish educational research journals, selected from the prominent national academic indexing database TR Dizin (TR Index) by The Scientific and Technological Research Council of Türkiye (TÜBİTAK). To identify relevant journals, a systematic search was conducted within the TR Dizin database using the "Education and Educational Research" category classification. All journals categorized under education-related fields were initially identified and retrieved from the database. The journals indexed in this specific national indexing database were selected based on their scope relevance to the field of education, their accessibility, and their significance in the Turkish academic landscape. As the publishing language (English) and educational scope of the journals were determined as inclusion criteria, those not published in English and not having a clearly educational scope were excluded from the sample of the study. The remaining 107 journals published by

universities, non-governmental scientific organisations, individual scholars, publishing companies, and government institutions consisted the sample for the present research (Table 1).

Table 1. Profile of the selected Turkish educational research journals

		n	%	Cum. %
Publisher type	University	71	66.4	66.4
	NGO	8	7.5	73.8
	Individual	24	22.4	96.3
	Company	2	1.9	98.1
	Other	2	1.9	100.0
Hosted by	DergiPark	89	83.2	83.2
	Website	15	14.0	97.2
	Platforms	3	2.8	100.0
International Index	No	54	50.5	50.5
	Yes	53	49.5	100.0
English language editor	None	24	22.4	22.4
	Linguist	72	67.3	89.7
	Non-linguist	11	10.3	100.0

The journal selection procedure is summarized in Figure 1, which briefly presents the steps taken determining the primary research sample for the present study. The policies of these journals regarding the AI use by the authors, reviewers, and editors were also analysed qualitatively in order to come up with findings regarding the existing policies, restrictions, and perspectives of scholarly journals.

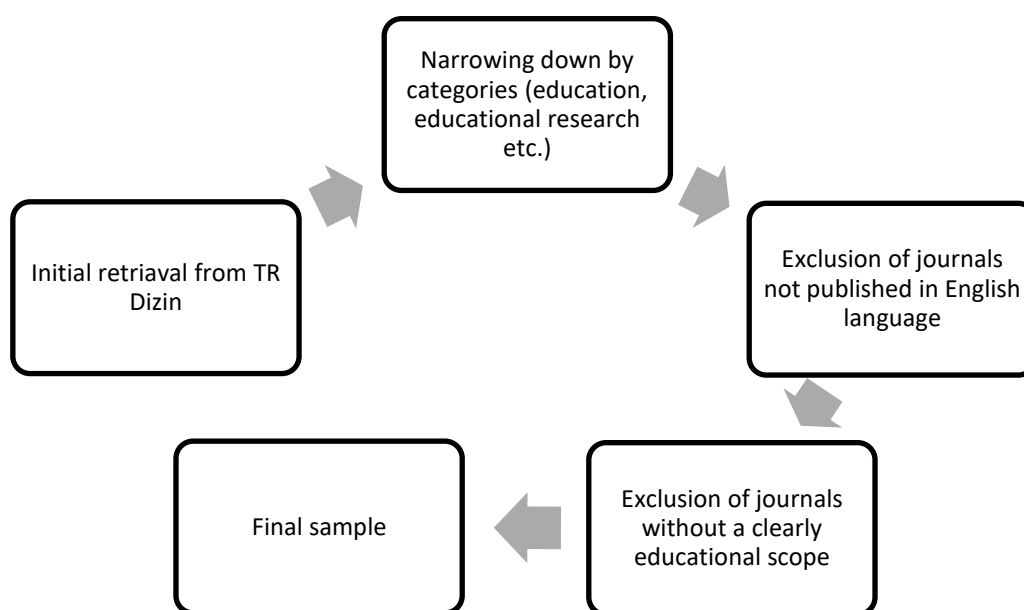


Figure 1. The flowchart of journal selection

Scholarly publishing stakeholders

As scholarly publishing process involves multiple roles with differing duties and responsibilities, the data were collected from a range of publishing roles in order to gain comprehensive insight into the perspectives of the stakeholders. Hence, for the semi-structured interviews, a purposive sampling strategy using the snowball sampling technique was employed to collect qualitative data from five key stakeholders involved in Turkish educational publishing. While the interview sample size is relatively small ($n=5$), this number is methodologically justified by the principles of purposive sampling and the achievement of role saturation in the present study. The selected participants represent all critical roles, ensuring maximum heterogeneity and structural coverage of the scholarly publishing. Furthermore, an analysis of the interviews indicated that thematic data saturation was reached, as no new critical themes or perspectives emerged regarding AI policy or ethical concerns after the final interview.

Participant 1: P1 is an individual publisher of an internationally indexed and recognized journal of educational research. He has been publishing the journal for a decade and it has been indexed in EBSCO (HW Wilson), TR Dizin, and SportDiscus. The journal is also under evaluation by Scopus and WoS (ESCI) indexing databases.

Participant 2: P2 is the Chief Editor of an educational journal publishing in English. The journal is currently indexed in Scopus, ERIC, and HW Wilson. The journal does not possess a standalone AI policy but it adheres to international ethical standards such as COPE.

Participant 3: P3 is the section editor of an educational research journal that has been published for more than 10 years. The journal is indexed in several international indexing services and databases.

Participant 4: P4 is the author of many educational manuscripts published in a range of journals indexed in TR Dizin, HW Wilson, Scopus, and other international indexes. P4 is particularly interested in educational technologies including digital competencies and generative artificial intelligence.

Participant 5: P5 is a faculty member in the field of educational sciences and she has been involved in numerous research projects. She was interviewed as a reviewer of educational research since she had completed more than 20 peer-reviews for various journals in the field in less than a year.

The diversity of the roles among the interviewees of the present study is expected to provide a comprehensive picture of the views and perspectives regarding the use of AI in scholarly publishing.

Instruments

The instrument for the content analysis was a coding framework developed to evaluate the AI use policies of the selected journals. This framework was designed to assess the presence or absence of AI-related guidelines, the types of AI tools mentioned (e.g., writing assistance, peer review, data analysis), and the ethical considerations regarding AI use (e.g., plagiarism, transparency, bias).

Additionally, the semi-structured interview protocol consisted of open-ended questions designed to explore the views of stakeholders on the use of AI in scholarly publishing by different stakeholders, the necessity and implementation of AI use policies in Turkish educational journals, the ethical concerns related to the integration of AI in academic publishing, and the perceived impact of AI on the future of scholarly publishing. The interview guide allowed for flexibility, enabling participants to share their insights while ensuring all relevant topics were covered.

Data Collection

The data for the content analysis were gathered by reviewing the editorial guidelines and submission policies of the 107 Turkish educational journals which successfully met the indexing criteria of TR Dizin. Selection of the journals was based on their inclusion in TR Dizin as of July 2025, ensuring the currency of the data. These documents were publicly available on the journals' websites or through academic databases. The review focused on identifying explicit references to AI use and related ethical considerations.

Semi-structured interviews that were conducted with the five stakeholders in academic publishing were carried out in-person or via video conferencing, depending on participant availability. Each interview lasted between 30-45 minutes. With the participants' consent, all interviews were recorded and transcribed for subsequent analysis.

Data Analysis

The data from the content analysis were analysed using a categorical coding approach. The AI-related policies were coded based on their presence or absence, the type of AI tools addressed, and the ethical concerns raised. The data were then categorized into themes to identify patterns and differences across journals. The qualitative interview data were analysed using thematic analysis. The interview transcripts were first read and re-read to identify recurring themes and key insights. The responses were coded and categorized into major themes, such as "AI necessity," "ethical concerns," and "future impact." Thematic analysis allowed for the identification of common perspectives, as well as divergent views among the stakeholders. The results were then compared with the findings from the content analysis to provide a comprehensive view of AI policies in Turkish educational journals.

Validity and Reliability Issues

To ensure the validity of the content analysis, a clear and systematic coding framework was developed. The framework was pilot-tested on a small subset of journals before being applied to the entire sample. Additionally, interrater reliability was ensured by having two independent researchers analyse a sample of journal policies and compare their findings. Discrepancies were resolved through discussion and consensus.

To enhance the validity of the interview data, a semi-structured approach was used to allow for in-depth responses while ensuring consistency across interviews. The interview guide was reviewed by two experts in academic publishing and qualitative research to ensure that the questions were relevant and comprehensive. Member checking was also employed, where two of the participants were provided with a summary of the interview findings to confirm the accuracy and reliability of the interpretations.

The reliability of the content analysis was addressed by maintaining consistency in the coding process across all 107 journals. The use of clear definitions and categories for AI-related policies ensured that the analysis could be replicated. For the interview data,

reliability was ensured by adhering to a consistent interview protocol and using standardized methods for data transcription and analysis.

Throughout the research process, ethical guidelines were followed. Informed consent was obtained from all interview participants, ensuring they understood the purpose of the research, their right to confidentiality, and their ability to withdraw at any time. Participant identities were anonymized, and all data were securely stored.

FINDINGS

Journal Policy Findings

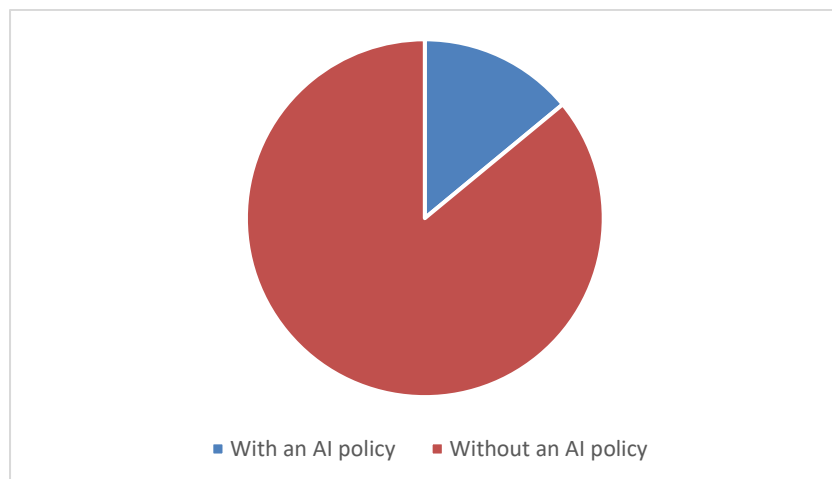


Figure 2. AI policy adoption of Turkish educational research journals

In order to draw a general picture of the AI policy integration of the Turkish educational journals, all the journals indexed in TR Dizin were carefully scanned and any declared AI policies were searched by the researcher and two other experts through data scraping. The findings indicated that only 14 % (n= 15) of the 107 journals analysed had a declared AI use policy (Figure 2). The contents extracted from these 15 journals with declared AI use policies were analysed qualitatively and the findings are summarized in Table 2.

Table 2. Policies of Turkish educational journals regarding the use of AI

Theme	Codes	Samples from Journal Policies
Permitted Uses of AI	Language editing, proofreading, literature review assistance, data analysis (in some cases)	"The use of artificial intelligence in processes such as literature review or language editing, which do not affect the originality of the article, is acceptable." (J14) "It (AI) can be used as a supportive tool in processes such as literature review, language check, and data analysis." (J68)
Prohibited Uses of AI	Generating original content, "... fabricated (by AI) data should definitely not be used for manipulating data or results, unethical purposes such as manipulation." (J14) creating "ghost authorship" (AI as a co-author)	"The Journal of the Faculty of Education at XXX University does not accept these tools as authors on the grounds that artificial intelligence tools cannot assume responsibility." (J50)
Authorship	AI cannot be listed as an author. Authors are solely performed by humans..." (J23, J31) responsible for the content and originality of the article.	"Authorship encompasses a range of tasks that can only be performed by humans..." (J23, J31)
Transparency	Authors must disclose the use of AI tools, including the artificial intelligence tools are used at various stages of type of tool, its purpose, and research—such as idea generation, research design how it was used.	"It is mandatory to clearly specify how and to what extent use of AI tools, including the artificial intelligence tools are used at various stages of type of tool, its purpose, and research—such as idea generation, research design development, data collection, analysis processes, and presentation of findings." (J50) "Transparent declaration includes a description of: What AI technology was used (the name of the technology), Why this AI technology was used (the reason for its use), How the AI technology was used (what the task of the technology was)." (J80)

Ethical Considerations	Data privacy and security, "The fundamental ethical values that must be adhered to in the fairness and bias, scientific use of AI are as follows: transparency, honesty, diligence, integrity, responsible use of fairness and respect, protection of privacy and confidentiality, AI accountability and taking responsibility, contributing to an ethical climate." (J68)
Consequences of Article rejection, potential Non-Compliance ethical violations	"Ethics and Research Integrity Violations: Situations such as not obtaining copyright for data or visuals, using artificial intelligence as a ghost-writer in publications, misrepresenting the plagiarism rate, or stating that no permission is needed for studies requiring ethical approval (lead to article rejection)." (J24)

As clearly seen in Table 2, the AI use policies Turkish educational journals publishing in English encompass a number of issues regarding the academic integrity and ethics. Though limited in number, the journals with an existing policy of AI use seem to clearly identify the permitted and prohibited uses of AI. To exemplify, J68 and J14 both allows the authors to utilize AI tools for proofreading and language editing purposes while they can go further to allow their use in reviewing the literature and analysing data. On the other hand, authorship of AI and data fabrication through AI tools are observed to be among the prohibited uses of GenAI technologies (J14, J50). The content analysis of the journal policies data also revealed that there is a consensus regarding the transparency in the authors' submissions. In other words, the authors are expected to declare any assistance of AI at any stage of the manuscript preparation. While addressing the controversial issue of AI use in manuscript preparation, Turkish educational journals seem to prioritize universal ethical considerations such as data privacy, bias, integrity, fairness. Despite the fact that the journals rely considerably on the declaration of authors regarding their use of AI technologies in scientific writing, they were found to have policies against unacceptable and irresponsible use of AI. J24, for example, clearly states that the authorship credited to any AI tools leads to the rejection of the articles as a journal policy.

To summarize, the policies declared by the Turkish educational journals publishing in English language share several common characteristics as illustrated in Table 3. In pursuit of the overall goal of balancing the potential benefits of AI tools with the indispensable need to maintain academic integrity, they seem to prioritize an ethics-oriented approach with a specific focus on transparency. That is why they declare a widespread demand to disclose any use of AI tools or application with rationale behind this action. Besides, they are commonly author-centric, which emphasizes the author(s)' role in the manuscript preparation process without allowing any AI tool to be declared as a co-author. In short, the journals in the sample of the present study are observed to adopt a cautious approach by highlighting the human agency and author responsibility in academic publishing as well as acknowledging the potential assistance and benefits of utilizing AI tools.

Table 3. Common characteristics of AI policies of educational research journals

Characteristic	Explanation
Cautious approach	Acknowledges potential benefits of AI tools (e.g., language editing) while emphasizing human oversight and author responsibility.
Author-centred	Prioritizes the author's role in ensuring research integrity and originality.
Transparency	Requires clear disclosure of AI tool usage, including type, purpose, and how it was used.
Ethics-oriented	Aligns with ethical principles like fairness, accuracy, and responsible AI use.
Overall goal	To balance the potential benefits of AI with the need to maintain research quality and integrity.

Interview Data Findings

The thematic analysis of the semi-structured interviews with the participants in various roles within the scholarly publishing process revealed the complexity of the phenomenon of AI use in scientific publishing.

Table 4. Stakeholders' perspectives on the use of AI in scholarly publishing

Theme	Sub-themes	Sample Codes
Adoption of AI policies	Consensus on the necessity of AI policies	AI policies are necessary Policies must be declared on websites or templates
	Lack of consistent AI policies in most journals	There are inconsistent policies Majority of journals do not have AI policies Policies imposed by global indexing services
Ethical boundaries of AI use	Permitted uses of AI	Grammar checks Minor edits

Disclosure and Transparency		Literature review assistance Data visualisation Translation
	Prohibited uses of AI	Full-text generation / authorship Data analysis and interpretation Data fabrication Editorial tasks and peer-reviews
	Necessity of disclosure	AI use must be disclosed in the methods or in a separate disclosure statement
	Lack of mandatory disclosure	Most journals lack disclosure obligation or sections/headings
	Difficulty in AI detection	Inefficient tools in detecting AI Human-like language of AI Self-disclosure of authors
Detection and enforcement		
	Lack of enforcement	Lack of global criteria of ethical AI Policies on paper without enforcement
	Lack of comprehensive policies in TR educational journals	No policy declarations at all Some unclear policies Unclear rejection criteria
Local & Global policy variances		
	More clear and rigid policies by global publishers	Clearly explained authorship issues Acceptable uses are declared Disclosure is required in a specified section Data availability is mandatory
Future of AI in scholarly publishing	Inevitable integration of AI in research	AI is the future of science and scholarly publication

As shown in Table 4, the participants of the current research illustrated a consensus on the necessity of AI policy adoption while pointing at the fact that most Turkish educational journals fail to have consistent and comprehensive policies regarding the use of AI by the stakeholders. It was also revealed by the participants -especially by those in editorial roles- that the few existing policies were indeed imposed by global publishers or indexing services without any national or local motive.

The qualitative analysis of the data revealed permitted and prohibited uses of AI tools during the manuscript preparation and evaluation processes, which yielded another emerging theme, the ethical boundaries of AI use. Under this main theme, AI was perceived as a trustable companion in certain tasks such as English language improvement, translation, data visualisation, and reviewing the existing literature while it was considered unethical to use it as an independent author, a fabricated data source, an independent interpreter of the results, an editor, or a reviewer.

The concerns related to transparency and disclosure emerged along with the associated challenges of detection and enforcement as two other interrelated themes in the present study. To be more precise, the participants clearly agreed that any potential use of AI in manuscript preparation must be disclosed by the authors, though many journals fail to oblige their authors to do so. On the other hand, the participants were well aware that it is not an easy task to detect AI use in a manuscript due to the limited capacities of the existing AI or plagiarism detection tools, and the seemingly natural, human-like language production of generative AI technologies. This situation results in the reliance of the journals and publishers on the self-disclosure of the authors regarding the use of AI in their studies. Moreover, the stakeholders emphasised the lack of globally accepted criteria of ethical AI use in research process with few exceptions such as authorship and transparency. Yet, even these exceptions are not subject to deterrent enforcement in research contexts like Türkiye.

DISCUSSION

The findings of this study reveal a significant gap in the adoption of AI use policies among Turkish educational journals, with only 14 % having declared policies. This low adoption rate aligns with the observations of Bhavsar et al. (2025), who noted that although 82.1 % of mainstream global publishers require authors to declare AI use, only 34.6 % have publicly available AI policies. The disparity between global and Turkish journals suggests that Turkish educational publications are still in the early stages of adapting to the challenges posed by generative AI technologies in scholarly publishing.

Current State of AI Use Policies in Turkish Educational Journals and Ethical Concerns

The limited number of Turkish educational journals with established AI policies reflects an emerging awareness rather than a comprehensive approach to addressing AI integration in scholarly publishing. This finding is consistent with Lund and Naheem's (2024) observation that AI policies in journals are often guided by publishers rather than individual journals. In the Turkish context,

interview data confirmed that "the few existing policies were indeed imposed by global publishers or indexing services without any national or local motive," suggesting a reactive rather than proactive approach to policy development.

The content analysis of existing policies reveals that Turkish educational journals with AI policies have established clear guidelines regarding permitted and prohibited uses of AI. These journals adopt what can be characterized as a "cautious approach" that acknowledges the potential benefits of AI while emphasizing human agency and author responsibility. This approach aligns with the Technology Acceptance Model (Davis, 1989), where the perceived usefulness of AI in tasks like proofreading and literature review has led to conditional acceptance, while concerns about more substantive uses remain. To illustrate, Haman and Školník (2023) have recently highlighted that AI tools frequently fail to access accurate resources and valid DOI numbers while preparing a literature review, and proving the vitality of human agency for content reliability. General tendencies of Turkish educational journals regarding the authorship issues seem to match those in the literature (Bhavsar et al., 2025) as they both prohibit the authorship of AI tools since they cannot be held responsible for the content they create. Likewise, the study's finding that 14% of journals permit AI use for language editing and proofreading directly reflects TAM's "perceived usefulness" construct (Davis, 1989) as Turkish educational journals recognize that AI applications enhance non-native English authors' performance without compromising academic integrity.

The ethical boundaries established by Turkish educational journals mirror the global discourse on responsible AI use in scholarly publishing. The identified permitted uses (language editing, proofreading, literature review assistance) and prohibited uses (generating original content, data manipulation, AI authorship) reflect the ethical considerations outlined by Borenstein and Howard (2021). General tendencies of Turkish educational journals regarding authorship issues match those in the literature (Bhavsar et al., 2025; Nature, 2023), as they prohibit AI authorship since AI tools cannot be held responsible for the content they create.

The findings of the present research also indicate that the implementation of such authorship policies seems to be inevitably left to the responsibility of the authors due to the challenges regarding the detection of AI in scholarly texts (Hu, 2024; Wiggers, 2023).

The emphasis on transparency and disclosure in the journal policies resonates with Information Ethics Theory (Floridi, 2013), which advocates for moral accountability in information ecosystems. The requirement for authors to "clearly specify how and to what extent artificial intelligence tools are used" (J50) demonstrates an attempt to establish normative boundaries for AI use in scholarly publishing. This finding directly operationalizes Floridi's (2013) principle of transparency as a prerequisite for ethical information creation. The study reveals that all 15 journals with AI policies mandate disclosure, embodying the information ethics tenet that information ownership and accountability require explicit attribution of AI contributions. However, as noted by García-Peñalvo (2023) and confirmed by interview participants, the difficulty in detecting AI-generated content makes enforcement challenging, leading to heavy reliance on author self-disclosure. This enforcement gap reveals a critical tension in information ethics implementation (Floridi, 2013); while journals establish normative frameworks for transparent information creation, the technical limitations of AI detection undermine the practical realization of these ethical principles.

Benefits and Challenges of AI Integration in Scholarly Writing

The findings highlight a nuanced perspective on the benefits and challenges of AI integration in Turkish educational journals. The interview data revealed that AI is "perceived as a trustable companion in certain tasks such as English language improvement, translation, data visualization, and reviewing the existing literature." This perception supports Barros et al.'s (2023) assertion that generative AI technology can ensure equity between native and non-native speakers of English, potentially addressing what Lillis and Curry (2010) identified as language barriers in scientific publications. However, the challenges associated with AI integration are substantial. The difficulty in detecting AI use, the human-like language production of generative AI technologies, and the lack of globally accepted criteria for ethical AI use create significant obstacles to effective policy implementation. These challenges are compounded by what Hu (2024) described as the lack of fully reliable means to enforce AI policies, making well-intentioned initiatives "likely to stay merely theoretical."

Comparison with International Best Practices

The comparison between Turkish educational journals' AI policies and international best practices reveals both similarities and discrepancies. The core principles identified in Turkish journal policies—transparency, author responsibility, ethical considerations—align with global standards as documented by Bhavsar et al. (2025) and Lund and Naheem (2024). However, the interview data revealed a "lack of comprehensive policies in TR educational journals" compared to the "more clear and rigid policies by global publishers."

This discrepancy can be understood within the context of what Teel et al. (2023) described as the crucial task for stakeholders to identify and eliminate risks caused by AI while determining its appropriate role in scholarly publishing. Turkish educational journals appear to be at an earlier stage of this process, with policy development often driven by external requirements rather than internally motivated initiatives.

Future Impact of AI on Scholarly Publishing in Türkiye

The participants' consensus on the "inevitable integration of AI in research" suggests that AI technologies will continue to shape scholarly publishing in Türkiye. This perspective aligns with Van Noorden and Perkel's (2023) finding that one-fourth of researchers worldwide use AI tools in manuscript preparation, a percentage that has likely increased since their study.

In the Turkish academic context, where researchers face significant pressure to publish in English-language journals for career advancement (the "publish or perish" atmosphere described in the literature review), AI tools could potentially serve as valuable assistants. However, the lack of comprehensive policies and enforcement mechanisms creates a regulatory vacuum that may lead to inconsistent practices across journals and researchers.

The extended TAM model (Venkatesh & Davis, 2000) provides a useful framework for understanding the future trajectory of AI adoption in Turkish scholarly publishing. As subjective norms around AI use evolve and perceived usefulness increases, journals may develop more comprehensive policies that balance the benefits of AI with ethical considerations. However, this development will require a shift from externally imposed policies to internally motivated initiatives that address the specific challenges faced by Turkish educational researchers. The integration of TAM and Information Ethics Theory in analyzing these findings reveals that successful AI policy development requires both technological acceptance (driven by perceived benefits) and ethical grounding (ensuring transparency and accountability). The study's results suggest Turkish journals are currently navigating the early stages of this dual challenge—recognizing AI's potential utility while struggling to establish robust ethical frameworks for its governance.

Implications for Policy Development

The findings of this study have several implications for the development of comprehensive AI use policies in Turkish educational journals. First, there is a need for greater consistency and clarity in AI policies across journals. The current fragmented approach, where only a small percentage of journals have declared policies, creates uncertainty for authors and editors.

Second, the emphasis on transparency and disclosure needs to be accompanied by practical mechanisms for implementation. As noted by Hosseini et al. (2023), publishers and editors rely heavily on authors regarding their potential use of generative AI technologies. This reliance creates a vulnerability in the system that could be addressed through more robust guidelines and education for all stakeholders.

Finally, the development of AI policies should be informed by the specific needs and challenges of Turkish educational researchers, particularly those related to publishing in English as a non-native language. The "publish or perish" pressure described in the literature review, combined with language barriers identified by Lillis and Curry (2010), creates a context where AI tools could be particularly valuable if used ethically and transparently.

Conclusion

This study provides a comprehensive examination of AI use policies in Turkish educational journals and the perspectives of key stakeholders on AI integration in scholarly publishing. The findings reveal a significant gap in policy adoption, with only a small percentage of journals having declared AI policies. Those journals with policies emphasize transparency, author responsibility, and ethical considerations, aligning with global trends in scholarly publishing.

The challenges associated with AI detection and enforcement, combined with the pressure on Turkish researchers to publish in English-language journals, create a complex environment for policy development. As AI technologies continue to evolve and their use in scholarly writing becomes more widespread, Turkish educational journals will need to develop more comprehensive and consistent policies that balance the benefits of AI with ethical considerations.

Recommendations

Based on the findings of this study examining AI use policies in Turkish educational journals publishing in English, several key recommendations emerge for the scholarly publishing ecosystem. First of all, Turkish educational journals should prioritize developing comprehensive and standardized AI use policies that clearly distinguish between acceptable and unacceptable AI uses while establishing transparent disclosure requirements. Besides, the Council of Higher Education and higher education institutions should create institutional-level AI policies, integrate AI literacy into research methodology programs, and initiate training programs to guide researchers in appropriate AI tool usage. Future research should focus on longitudinal studies tracking policy evolution, comparative analyses with international journals, and impact assessments of policy effectiveness. Implementation should follow a gradual approach with immediate priority given to policy development and stakeholder education, accompanied by regular monitoring and updating mechanisms to ensure policies remain effective as AI technologies continue to advance.

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